



## CONCEPT NOTE

### 3rd Annual East Africa Guild Leaders' Summit – 2026

**Theme:** *Youth Leadership, Production, and Regional Integration: Building a Competitive East Africa in a Changing Global Order*

**Dates:** 23<sup>rd</sup> and 24<sup>th</sup> July 2026

**Venue:** Makerere University, Kampala – Freedom Square

**Chief Guest:** **Yoweri Kaguta Museveni**, President of the Republic of Uganda & Chairperson of the East African Community

**Convened by:** Guild Presidents Leadership Academy (GPLA)

#### 1. Background and Rationale:

East Africa stands at a critical juncture shaped by shifting global geopolitics, increasing competition for markets and resources, and the urgent need for regional self-reliance. At the center of this moment is the growing recognition that **political and economic integration is not optional, but strategic** for the region's stability, bargaining power, and long-term prosperity.

The current leadership of the East African Community under **Yoweri Kaguta Museveni** has consistently emphasized the need for **larger markets, productive economies, and coordinated regional action** as the foundation for transformation. This thinking is further reinforced by ongoing regional initiatives, including the **joint East African bid to host the 2027 Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON)**, which symbolizes not only sports diplomacy but also infrastructure development, regional cooperation, and economic integration.

With over 70% of the region's population being youth, the success of these ambitions depends on how effectively young leaders are mobilized, organized, and oriented toward production, innovation, and regional thinking.

University Guild Leaders occupy a unique position as **structured leaders with constituencies, legitimacy, and influence** within institutions that shape future policymakers, entrepreneurs, and public servants. The Guild Presidents Leadership Academy (GPLA) has, over the past two Summits, built a credible regional platform for engaging these leaders in governance, integration, and development discourse.

The **3rd Annual Guild Leaders' Summit** at Makerere University seeks to consolidate this momentum by aligning youth leadership with the region's strategic priorities – **integration, production, markets, and competitiveness** – while positioning young people as active participants in shaping East Africa's future.

To date, GPLA has successfully convened two high-level Guild Leaders' Summits at **Makerere University**, hosted by distinguished African Statesmen. The inaugural Summit in 2024 was graced by **HE. Jakaya Mrisho Kikwete, Former President the United Republic of Tanzania**, who subsequently accepted to serve as **Patron of the Guild Leaders' Summit**.

The Second edition in 2025 hosted **HE. Uhuru Kenyatta, Former President of the Republic of Kenya as Chief Guest**, further elevating the Summit's Regional Profile and Impact.

The Academy is guided by experienced and respected Leadership, including **DR. Ruhakana Rugunda as Patron of GPLA**, and **Hon. Canon Matthew Rukikaire as a key member of its Advisory Board**. With a growing and active presence across Uganda, Kenya, Tanzania, and Rwanda, GPLA continues to strengthen Youth Leadership Networks as a cornerstone for East Africa's Democratic Governance and People-to-People Integration.

This **2026 Edition** is envisioned as a defining Pan-African Youth Leadership Movement, bringing together Young Leaders and Heads of State who embody Africa's Past, Present, and Future Leadership Philosophies.

## **2. Goal**

To Mobilize and Equip East African Student Leaders to actively contribute to Regional Integration, Economic Transformation, and Strategic positioning of East Africa in a changing Global Order.

## **3. Specific Objectives**

1. To deepen Youth understanding and commitment to **East African Political and Economic Integration**.
2. To promote a **Production-oriented Mindset** among Young Leaders aligned to Regional Development Priorities.
3. To explore opportunities for Youth participation in **Regional Markets, Trade, and Industrialization**.
4. To leverage Regional initiatives such as **AFCON 2027** as platforms for Youth Engagement, Economic growth, and Integration.
5. To strengthen collaboration between Youth Leaders, Government, and Regional institutions in advancing the Integration Agenda.

## **4. Key Focus Areas**

### **1. Political and Economic Integration**

Understanding the strategic importance of a United East Africa in Strengthening Markets, Security, and Global competitiveness.

## **2. Youth, Production and Industrial Transformation**

Shifting Youth focus from job-seeking to **Production, Value Addition, and Enterprise Development**.

## **3. Regional Markets, Trade and Economic Opportunities**

Positioning Young people to participate in **Cross-border Trade, Regional value chains, and Intra-African commerce**

## **4. Sports Diplomacy and Regional Integration (AFCON 2027)**

Leveraging the East African joint hosting of AFCON as a platform for:

- Youth Employment
- Infrastructure Development
- Regional Branding and Unity

## **5. Technology, Innovation and the Digital Economy**

Harnessing digital tools to enhance Productivity, Governance, and Economic participation

## **6. Education, Mobility and Knowledge Integration**

Strengthening collaboration among Universities to support **Skills Development, Research, and Regional knowledge systems**

## **5. Summit Structure**

### **Day One: Markets, Innovation and Youth Opportunity**

- **Panel-1:** Enhancing Trade through East African Integration: Challenges and Opportunities
- **Panel-2:** AFCON 2027 as a Platform for Youth Economic Participation
- **Panel-3:** University Leaders Dialogue: Education and Regional Mobility
- **Panel-4:** Agri-tech Innovations for Youth-led Solutions in Regional Food Security and Climate Justice.
- Adoption of the **Makerere Youth Declaration on Integration and Production**

### **Day Two: Integration, Leadership and Strategic Direction**

- Opening Ceremony
- **Chief Guest Address:** *The Future of East African Integration and Youth Leadership*
- **Panel-1:** Youth, Production and National Development
- Intergenerational Engagement with Policy Leaders

## 6. Expected Outputs

1. **Makerere Youth Declaration on East African Integration and Production**
2. **Youth Policy Proposals** on Trade, Markets, and Economic Participation
3. **Regional Student Leadership Network Strengthening**
4. **Action Plans** for Campus-based Implementation
5. **Summit Report and Policy Briefs**

## 7. Expected Outcomes

- Increased Youth alignment with Regional Integration and Production Agendas
- Enhanced participation of Young people in **Trade, Enterprise, and Regional Markets**
- Strengthened collaboration between Universities and Regional Institutions
- Greater Youth awareness of opportunities under **Regional initiatives such as AFCON 2027**
- Development of a Generation of Leaders committed to **Self-reliance, Integration, and Economic Transformation**

## 8. Conclusion

The **3rd Annual Guild Leaders' Summit at Makerere University** presents a strategic opportunity to align East Africa's Youth Leadership with the Region's core priorities of **Integration, Production, and Competitiveness**. By connecting Young Leaders to practical pathways for participation in Regional Development, the Summit will contribute to building a United, Resilient, and Forward-looking East Africa.

*The Future of East Africa will not be Inherited, it will be Built.*

*And the Builders are here.*